

Australia is home to about 400 shark and ray species out of the 1,100 or so species found worldwide. Around 160 of these species are believed to be only found in Australian waters.

Australia has joined with other states in committing to ensure the conservation and management of sharks and their long-term sustainable use. These commitments are summarised in the International Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks. As part of this agreement, Australia has made voluntary commitments under its National Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks.

Shark fisheries in Australia

In Australia, a limited number of species are caught in targeted shark-fishing operations. Sharks are also caught as byproduct or bycatch where other species are being targeted.

Sharks have been important to the cultural identity of many coastal First Nations communities as well as being captured for food or as products for trade. Indigenous Australian fishers continue to take small numbers of sharks, particularly in Australia's tropical waters.

Some recreational fishers and charter boat operators target sharks both for harvest and as a 'catch and release' species. In comparison to many other commonly eaten marine species, sharks generally have a low reproduction rate, reach sexual maturity later, and often have small total populations. This can make them susceptible to overfishing and slow to recover if stocks are overfished.

In Commonwealth-managed fisheries, catch limits are set to ensure populations are maintained at sustainable levels. There are stricter rules in place where a shark species is listed as protected, endangered or threatened under the Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999 (EPBC Act).

Each of these species has a recovery plan in place (or under development) that guides fisheries managers in setting rules for these species. Commercial fishers are required to report any interaction with an EPBC Act listed shark species. In Commonwealth waters, the Australian Fisheries Management Authority is responsible for setting and enforcing the specific rules governing sharks and commercial fishing operations.

Australia regularly reviews its management arrangements to ensure sharks are managed, using the best available scientific and biological information.

Monitoring the health of our shark populations

The Fisheries Research and Development Corporation (FRDC) has funded two independent assessments of sharks and rays in Australian waters.

In FRDC's [2023 Australian Shark and Ray Report Card](#), a total of 331 species of sharks and rays in Australian waters were assessed. The research found that stocks of Australia's sharks and rays are in relatively good condition, and that Australia's shark management is world leading.

Of the 19 shark and ray species assessed as depleted, most are listed as protected and are being actively managed through recovery plans.

Australia's National Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks

Australia's National Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks (Shark-plan) details actions to encourage the effective and sustainable management of Australia's shark populations.

The national document encourages improved management of sharks in Commonwealth, state and Northern Territory managed waters. It provides guidance to fisheries and conservation managers and other resource users to improve the conservation and management of sharks.

The Shark-plan also meets Australia's commitment as a member of the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization (UN FAO), to the International Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks ([IPOA-Sharks](#)).

Australia first developed a National Plan of Action in 2004 (called Shark-plan 1) which has been regularly reviewed since then.

Following one of these reviews, in 2012, the Shark-plan Representative Group (SRG) was established. This group brings together Commonwealth, state and Northern Territory Government fisheries and conservation agencies with a wide range of non-government stakeholders. SRG's main responsibility is to monitor the implementation of the commitments made in the Shark-plan.

The most recent review in 2023 was informed by the [Shark Assessment Report](#) conducted by the Australian Bureau of Resource Economics and Science (ABARES) and feedback from key stakeholders through the SRG.

Shark-plan 2 articulates how Australia manages sharks and ensures that Australia meets international conservation and management obligations. The plan identifies research and management actions across Australia for the long-term sustainability of sharks, including actions to help minimise the impacts of fishing on sharks.

The Australian Fisheries Management Forum, including representatives from the Australian Government, Northern Territory and state fisheries management agencies, adopted the Revised Shark-plan 2 in April 2024.

Changes to the Shark-plan recognise that many actions have been completed, including the implementation of legislation to ban the practise of shark-finning.

The plan has moved to a monitoring, education and enforcement stage.

The review also noted the emergence of new issues impacting the conservation and management of sharks, particularly climate change.

Download

[Australia's Revised Second National Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks 2012 \(Revised Shark-plan 2\) \(PDF 219 KB\)](#) [Australia's Revised Second National Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks 2012 \(Revised Shark-plan 2\) \(DOCX 34 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Shark-plan Representative Group

The Shark-plan Representative Group oversees and reports on the implementation of the operational strategy for Shark-plan.

The SRG meets regularly and includes representatives from the state and Northern Territory fisheries agencies, AFMA, the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (including ABARES), the Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority (GBRMPA), FRDC, First Nations, the commercial and recreational fishing sectors and environmental non-government organisations. Relevant documents from the SRG meetings are available below.

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Implementing Shark-plan

The Commonwealth, state and Northern Territory governments all give an annual update on Shark-plan actions.

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Shark Assessment Reports

ABARES publishes Shark Assessment Reports that provide a snapshot of the sustainability of most of the shark populations across Australia, with a particular focus on the impacts of fishing.

The [Shark Assessment Report 2022](#) informed the 2023 review of the National Plan of Action.

The report also meets one of Australia's commitments under the UN FAO IPOA Sharks and Australia's National Plan of Action for the Conservation and Management of Sharks.

Both the Shark Assessment Report 2022, and the earlier version from 2018, found that the standard of Australian fisheries management processes is widely acknowledged to be high, and Australia can demonstrate progress against the goals outlined by the FAO.

The 2022 report noted that the management and conservation of sharks in Australia continues to improve. But concerns were raised that some Australian sharks, which are part of transboundary stocks, are being targeted outside Australian waters in areas close to our Exclusive Economic Zone.

The next Shark Assessment Report is expected to be published prior to 2030.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/fisheries/environment/sharks>